

From being self-taught to writing for *Nature*: Q&A with Freelance Science Journalist Dyna Rochmyaningsih

Dyna Rochmyaningsih began her science journalism career in rural Indonesia, where she still resides today. To date, she has written for Science Magazine, Nature, and National Geography, amongst many other outlets. In 2024, she was named a Knight Science Journalism (KSJ) Fellow at Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) and most recently was the journalist-in-residence at the Max Planck Institute in Berlin. She writes about a variety of topics at the intersection of science and society, policy, and religion; reporting on critical issues such as the environmental crisis and suppression of science in Indonesia.

In this interview, I ask Dyna how she got started in science journalism, what it's like writing in tense situations, and what motivates her career.

Q: Were you always interested in science? Do you have any formal science education?

I have always been fascinated with biology and science in general. In my undergraduate degree, I studied biology—however, I wasn't really good at performing labs or going into the field. But I liked writing, so I thought I would like to contribute by writing about science. In the final year of my undergraduate degree, I did neuroscience-related research on Monday-Thursday fasting services for my thesis. It's a ritual that we have in the Muslim world, especially also in Indonesia, where people fast every Monday and Thursday. I found that this was a great blend of science and societal interests.

So, I wrote my thesis and then published it in the Undergraduate Journal of Young Investigators. I also translated it into a popular version, and apparently the editor was interested. And then there it was—my first popular article.

Q: How did you get started in science journalism?

After graduation, while all my friends got jobs and scholarships, somehow, it just didn't happen for me. But I knew I really liked writing, so I just continued my passion in science writing, filling up this gap year of sorts, and gave me free time to explore.

Back around that time, around 2008 or 2009, the world became more and more connected, and the internet became much cheaper. So, I got this computer and an Internet connection, and I learned science journalism by myself—online, with a lot of trial and error. Slowly but surely, through many mistakes, I developed a network and bylines. So even though it's small, it builds up.

I was also learning about science journalism online from the World Federation of Science Journalists website, which has offices in sub-Saharan Africa, in South Asia, and in Latin

America. Eventually, they noticed me and contacted me. They were like, “Hey, we’re having this science journalist training, would you like to join?”

That’s the kind of thing I needed—and that’s how things started in my earliest career.

Q: What is the most interesting thing you’ve written about?

I have written a lot of articles in 12 years...but lately I was writing about the repatriations of the Homo erectus fossils. As you may know, the first Homo erectus ever discovered was in Java, in Indonesia. There were some previous articles, but when I looked into reports and talked to historians, I learned about many things that got underreported and buried.

Also, I spent my last two months in the Max Planck Institute for the History of Science in Berlin. That really gave me insights into how to look at this specific story. We always think that Western science grew and they brought modern science to the global South, as if we don’t have knowledge at all about many things.

And regarding the fossil itself, I just learned that it was found in an area that was known by locals as “the battlefields of the giants”. So, when farmers found these bones, they thought that it was the bones of a mythical giant. I find that fascinating. These farmers reported this to Indonesian scientists and to the painter and Javanese nobleman Raden Saleh. He was the one who visited the field and gave scientific meaning to it. His report only reached Eugene Dubois 30 years later. This kind of connection was never really written in the history of science.

I also look at this story as blending the past’s mythology and the cutting-edge science, with the possibility of future research extracting the ancient DNA. It makes a good combination in the story, and I’m quite proud of it.

But these interesting fun things are just the minority of my bylines. Most of my articles are about politics, science policy, and environmental crisis, which is a little more depressing.

Q: What is it like to write about these tough subjects?

In 2018 to 2022, I covered the suppression of science, where scientists were being censored by the Indonesian government through intimidation. It was a really sensitive time and emotionally exhausting.

I’ll give you an example: the development of hydropower project in North Sumatra. In 2019, a hydropower project was being built within the habitats for the most threatened orangutan species, and the project was supported by the Indonesian government.

A scientist contacted me and said, “There's something wrong about it, because the scientists who were outspoken suddenly stopped speaking out.” He told me how scientists had to choose between being fired or staying quiet. I wrote it down, and my editor really liked it. They said I was very brave. But actually, I’m not brave. I just wrote everything that I knew—I wrote it down the way that it was. And later when it was published, the scientist I used for my source was really mad at me. Similarly, when I wrote another story about the Indonesian government and the suppression of conservation scientists, one of them called me and said, “What are you doing?”

He said, “You're not doing anything for Indonesian conservation, you’re only doing this for fame. You should stop your work.” So that kind of thing really affected me emotionally.

But at the same time, I got appreciation from other scientists saying, “Thank you so much for writing this, because we could not speak out. If you didn't write it, no one would know about this oppression.”

Q: Looking back, what are the pivotal moments of your career?

Maybe, it was my decision to aim high. When I was in Indonesia, I tried to send it to an American publication, right? After my training with the World Federation of Science Journalists, I decided to aim for *Nature*.

What is the definition of ambition? If the definition of ambition is that you aim high for something, but then you just try and force yourself to reach that, I'm not that kind of person. When I set a goal and I tried and it doesn't work, I let it go.

So maybe I’m not a very persistent person, but I like to set the target a little bit high for excitement in life. And you never know. And when you do get it, you get a deeper appreciation for yourself. But I think being able to set the goal like, okay, I want to write for *Nature* or I want to get this MIT fellowship—like many people would say, don't ever think about it, or dream about it.

But I think dreaming is something that's free. Everyone could do it. Having dreams in mind actually guides you to the right path. Whether or not you fail, you are going in that direction.

Written by Doris Hua during FSCI 500 in Fall 2025